

MATTEO GRIGOLETTO

PhD in Economics

Expertise: Behavioral Science, Computational Methods, Causal Inference

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📍 Zurich, CH (Italian, CH resident with work visa B, soon C)

ABOUT ME

Behavioral economist with a dual profile: PhD-level expertise in causal inference and computational methods for studying how narratives and information shape human decisions, combined with hands-on program leadership in complex, multi-stakeholder and field environments. My research directly addresses the knowledge-action gap at the core of system transformation challenges. I design and conduct large-scale behavioral experiments, apply NLP and large language models to political and social discourse, and translate evidence into actionable insights for institutional change. I have built and led research programs from the ground up in both controlled and field settings, including with indigenous communities in the Amazon.

EDUCATION

PhD in Economics

Final: Summa cum laude • GPA: 5.88/6 • Dissertation: 6/6

University of Bern & Wyss Academy for Nature

2021 – 2025

Bern, CH

MSc in Economics

Final: 110/110 summa cum laude • GPA: 28.31/30

University of Pisa & Scuola Superiore Sant'Anna (joint)

2017 – 2019

Pisa, IT

Causality and Impact Evaluation Course

Erasmus University Rotterdam

2017

Rotterdam, NL

B.A. in Economics, Markets & Institutions

University of Bologna

2014 – 2017

Bologna, IT

RESEARCH OUTPUT

Virality: What Makes Narratives Go Viral and Does it Matter?

2025 • w/ Gehring • Working Paper

Censorship in Democracy

2025 • w/ Caesmann, Gschwent • Working Paper

Breaking the Gridlock: Zero-Sum Thinking, Identity and Mutually Beneficial Reforms

Ongoing • w/ Fernandez, Gehring, Weiss

From Villain to Hero: Aspirational Narratives & Technology Adoption Among Miners

Ongoing • w/ Fernandez, Gehring, Weiss

Making Villains Great Again: Populist Entrepreneurs & Public Discourse

Ongoing • w/ Gehring

Böswichte gehen viral: Warum politische Narrative Entscheidungen prägen

2026 • w/ Gehring • ifo Schnelldienst

[Google Scholar](#) • [Personal website: Research](#)

POLICY OUTREACH

Analysing Climate Change Policy Narratives: A Character-Role Framework

2024 • VoxEU / CEPR • cepr.org/voxeu

Censorship to Defend Democracy

2025 • VoxEU / CEPR • cepr.org/voxeu

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

Economist | PhD University of Bern

2021 – 2025
Bern, CH

- **Designed and conducted 50+ behavioral experiments (5,000+ participants; online, field, and lab)** measuring the causal effect of narrative framing, media content, and identity cues on beliefs, preferences, and real-stakes decisions; exploring the behavioral mechanisms motivating and driving economic and social change.
- **Applied LLMs and computational linguistics** to analyze how political narratives and AI-generated content reshape public discourse and policy preferences, producing **measurement-ready behavioral indicators from large-scale unstructured text data**.
- Co-managed and tutored several **research assistants** across nationalities; taught **dedicated seminar on causal reasoning and evidence generation** at Wyss Academy for Nature.
- Collaborated with **15+ international teams** ensuring high-quality data collection and analysis.

Lab-in-the-Field Experiment Coordination Wyss Academy for Nature

2023 – 2025
Madre de Dios, PE & Piura, PE

- Initiated and managed a **\$100k+ behavioral change program in the Peruvian Amazon**: led **cross-country teams (Switzerland, Peru, U.S.)** from intervention design through evidence collection, analysis, and dissemination; exploring a full theory-of-change cycle in a real-world field setting.
- **Developed innovative behavioral intervention approaches** using documentary film as a lever for attitude and technology adoption change among artisanal miners, integrating qualitative and quantitative evidence generation.
- Engaged directly with **indigenous communities** in remote areas, building cross-cultural communication and stakeholder engagement competencies in politically and ecologically sensitive contexts.

Project Development for Carbon Credits in Kenya Wyss Academy for Nature

2022 – 2025
Bern, CH & Nanyuki, KE

- **Co-designed contract for \$350k Monitoring, Reporting and Verification (MRV) framework**; defining indicators, data requirements, and reporting outputs to track environmental, social, and governance outcomes aligned with a theory of change for landscape-level transformation in Kenya.
- **Translated complex field data into evidence-based reports** for international partners, local governments, and NGOs; led a **50+ participant capacity-building workshop** on M&E tools and processes.

External Consultant Joint Research Center, European Commission

2019 – 2019
Ispra, IT

- Supported the **Monitoring and Impact Evaluation Unit** of the European Commission with evidence-based assessments of institutional and policy performance in an international governance setting.
- **Co-authored evaluation reports and strategic recommendations** on the allocation of the EU's 7-year budget 2021–2027, translating complex analytical findings into guidance for senior leadership.

Intern, Research Assistant University of Zurich & Harvard Business School

2020 – 2021
Zurich, CH & Remote

- **Trained transformer models** for text classification; implemented SpaCy and Hugging Face NLP pipelines, **reaching top-of-field performance** on classification benchmarks.
- Supported **data collection and database initiation**, conducted quantitative analysis, and performed systematic literature reviews.

AWARDS & ACHIEVEMENTS

Young Economist Award by Austrian Economic Association, 2023

Young Economist Award by Swiss Society of Economics and Statistics, 2025

Solo Keynote Speaker at Bocconi University, Collegio Carlo Alberto, Université Paris Dauphine, and Università della Svizzera italiana

Annual Guest Lecturer: AI and Machine Learning in Economic Research at the University of Bern (master- and graduate-level)

TECHNICAL EXPERTISE & LANGUAGES

Programming: Python (5 years), Stata (9), R (2), Git (2), LaTeX (9), SQL (1), Qualtrics (2), OpenAI API & OpenRouter API (2), Hugging Face (3), Spacy, Amazon MTurk (2), Claude Code

Methods: Causal Inference, Difference-in-Differences, Regression Discontinuity Design, Matching, RCT, A/B Testing, Natural Language Processing, Large Language Models, Transformer Models, Machine Learning, Agentic AI Workflows, Theory of Change, Impact Evaluation, M&E, Data Visualization, Policy Analysis

Languages: Italian (native), English (near native), Spanish (field experience), German (basic)